

Definition Drift Debate Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	definition-drift-debate

Big idea: Definitions stabilize inquiry, but they can also shift with purpose, power, and context.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students trace how a key term changes across contexts and debate whether changing definitions change knowledge.

Student Prompt

Inspect Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Term: intelligence; definitions from test performance, adaptive behavior, creativity, social understanding, and problem-solving. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Definition Drift Debate Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Definition Drift Debate Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Definitions stabilize inquiry, but they can also shift with purpose, power, and context.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	Do definitions describe reality or help construct it?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how definitions stabilize inquiry, but they can also shift with purpose, power, and context.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Do definitions describe reality or help construct it?

Setup Checklist

- Pick one term with genuine but manageable ambiguity.
- Use a specific purpose for the debate, such as school policy, research, classification, or exhibition commentary.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Term: intelligence; definitions from test performance, adaptive behavior, creativity, social understanding, and problem-solving.
- Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/definition-drift-debate/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/definition-drift-debate/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/definition-drift-debate/visual-prompt.svg>
- Definition comparison table: includes, excludes, evidence needed, who benefits.
- Borderline case cards that test each definition.

Run Sequence

1. Choose a term such as intelligence, health, art, risk, fairness, or success.
2. Groups receive different definitions and list what each definition includes and excludes.
3. Students apply each definition to borderline examples.
4. Groups debate which definition is most useful for a specific purpose.

5. Debrief how definitions can shape what evidence counts.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Do definitions describe reality or help construct it?
- Who should have authority to define contested terms?
- When does changing a definition improve knowledge and when does it manipulate it?

Teacher Quick Script

- A definition is doing work. What work is this definition doing?
- Which cases become easier or harder to know under this definition?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...